

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur

Sewage and rainwater sharing 'chambers' in Judge Colony

Residents of this enclave in Tambaram Sanatorium point an accusing finger at a government-run working women's hostel noting that the facility is letting sewage into the stormwater drain with impunity



The SWD running alongside Second Main Road in Judge Colony. PHOTO: T. ARVIND

T. ARVIND

A stormwater drain meant to carry rainwater has turned into a channel for sewage in Judge Colony, a quiet residential enclave in Tambaram Sanatorium, triggering concerns over public health, environmental degradation and groundwater contamination.

Residents of the locality, which

falls under Ward 34, Zone 3 of Tambaram Corporation, allege that excess sewage from a State government-run working women's hostel is being discharged into the stormwater drain along Second Main Road. The practice, they say, has resulted in stagnant sewage, foul smell and serious health risks in an otherwise pleasant neighbourhood.

Judge Colony, home to more than 1,000 residents including re-

tired judges, government officials and professionals, also houses a working women's hostel, a school and a care centre for persons with disabilities.

Groundwater concerns

According to S.M. Govindarajan, founder-president of the United Federation of Residents' Welfare Associations under Tambaram Corporation, said the stormwater drain

was constructed to channel excess rainwater from GST Road near the TB Hospital towards the eastern side. However, a technical issue in the alignment of a railway box culvert has impeded the flow of water. While the consequent water stagnation on GST Road is a separate concern, the drain in Judge Colony now largely carries sewage discharged from nearby establishments.

The sewage stagnates at several locations due to the absence of adequate flow, resulting in foul odour, mosquito breeding and fears of groundwater contamination. "What was conceived as a stormwater drain has virtually become a sewage channel," Govindarajan alleged.

Geetha, a homemaker, said the quality of groundwater had deteriorated considerably. "The water drawn from borewells and open wells has turned dark. Many families are forced to purchase drinking water," she said. Neeraja, another resident, said the stagnant sewage near her residence had become a persistent problem. "Infrequent desilting worsens the situation. The stagnant water also affects electrical appliances," she said.

Residents pointed out that despite the widespread use of reverse osmosis systems, groundwater in several houses remains unfit for consumption because of suspected contamination.

The issue has gained significance as several parts of Tambaram Sanatorium, Chitlapakkam and neighbouring localities are yet to be covered by an underground drainage network.

Security concerns

Residents also highlighted security issues along the stretch. According to them, several CCTV cameras installed along the storm water drain have become defunct.

"Visitors to the women's hostel frequently use this road. Considering safety concerns, the damaged cameras should be restored and monitoring strengthened," said Ramaswamy, a retired Deputy Collector.

Residents seek action

Calling for immediate intervention, Govindarajan urged the authorities to prevent sewage from entering the stormwater drain and insisted that the hostel install a sewage treatment plant (STP).

When contacted, Tambaram Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran said complaints had been received regarding the discharge of excess sewage from the women's hostel and a few commercial establishments in the area.

"We have ordered desilting of the storm water drain as an immediate measure. Instructions have also been given to identify and block sewage discharge points," he said.

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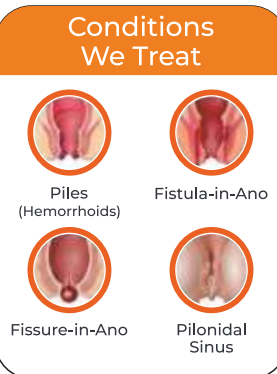
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‘Provide water supply to Thiruneermalai residents’



B. SARAVANAN

On May 12, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay directed officials of the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department and the Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department to ensure uninterrupted drinking water supply across the State during summer.

He asked officials to ensure the smooth distribution of water through tanker lorries, the construction of new borewells, and other alternative arrangements wherever necessary. The District Collectors were asked to inspect the supply facilities every Monday and undertake continuous monitoring to prevent shortages. It has been more than a month, but none of these above directives have been followed.

The residents of Saraswathipuram, Saraswathipuram Extension, Ranga Nagar, Subburayan Nagar, Kasi Garden, and Temple Town in the Thiruneermalai region, which

comes under Ward 31 of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, lack access to the Palar drinking water scheme or any other drinking water scheme.

For more than four years, the localities, which come under the Corporation's limits, have been suffering without basic amenities.

In February, a ‘Bhoomi Puja’ was held for the construction of an overhead water tank at Subburayan Nagar. However, the construction is progressing slowly, and the pipeline work is yet to begin. Residents store water in sumps and purchase water cans.

The Corporation should take steps to provide water to the residents by tankers.

The Budget session of the 17th Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly has begun. J. Kamatchi Jayachandran, Member of Legislative Assembly for the Pallavaram Assembly constituency, should take up the issue in the Assembly.

B. Saravanan is a resident of Thiruneermalai

‘Regulate Babu Street junction in Chitlapakkam’

P. THIAGARAJAN

Chitlapakkam Main Road is an important link road connecting Velachery Main Road and GST Road.

Hundreds of four-wheelers, autorickshaws, and two-wheelers negotiate this road daily to reach Tambaram Sanatorium and Mahalakshmi Nagar.

At the junction of Babu Street, Chitlapakkam Main Road, and Balaji Avenue, there is heavy traffic from 7 a.m. to 11 a.m. and 4.30 p.m. to 9 p.m.

Motorists negotiate this junction at breakneck speed, without regard for pedestrians intending to cross from Babu Street to Chitlapakkam Main Road or from Balaji Avenue to Babu Street.

With educational institutions having reopened, there is more traffic and that adds to the risk quotient.

Senior citizens and elderly people find it difficult to cross this section.

The Tambaram City Police Commissionerate's traffic wing should deploy personnel to regulate the traffic during peak hours.

‘Levy uniform water charge for areas under Tambaram Corporation’

L. SUNDARARAMAN

The Tambaram City Municipal Corporation should levy a uniform water tax for regions under its jurisdiction.

Ever since Chitlapakkam came under the Corporation limits, residents have been paying

₹100 every month.

Moreover, the water is supplied once every 15 days.

In the adjoining Chromepet and Pammal regions, the charge is ₹50 per month.

The differential tax rates are not acceptable.

L. Sundararaman is a resident of Chitlapakkam



You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

‘Big Street Boys’ drive vulture conservation initiative

Led by Keelkatalai resident Raghunath Krishna, the 1986 batch of The Hindu Higher Secondary School is taking a critical message about this bird to school students

PRINCE FREDERICK

Raghunath Krishna is the fly-wheel driving an initiative by alumni of The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane, the 1986 batch of the school, self-christened Big Street Boys. If the christening had happened in 1986 the day after the farewell, they need not tender any explanation to Backstreet Boys (est. 1993). If so, the American pop boy band would owe the boys from Triplicane a clear explanation.

On the topic at hand, Raghunath's felt-tip caricature pen (sometimes, a pencil or a piece of charcoal) scripts what would easily pass off as a “reaching-out, giving-back” story.

Trained by Raghunath, that pen has a demonstrated history of coaxing grotesquely attention-grabbing images out of the mundane. It is now at the centre of a visual vulture conservation project for school students.

These children would be reminded every day about the bird that is lagging in the numbers game. Raghunath has designed labels to be pasted on school notebooks, and these carry caricatured representations of vultures, portraying them not as carrion-devouring toughies, but cute and cuddle-worthy pets. The facts can be fed to the children later, get their attention first; that thinking is evidently at play.

He observes that his caricature



pen is swayed by two philosophies: draw with the a symbol of the target group pinned in the tack board in front of you; and two, no design that ever was effective was put the viewer to sleep, overpowering them with ennui. Hence no posters larded with data, just plain caricatures; info posters are necessary, but work only on the follow-up trail. Raghunath's lessons on caricaturing animals for conservation can be viewed at his YouTube Channel, Pencils Rock Academy.

On June 18, the alumni group distributed a huge set of these labels to students of Olcott school at Besant Nagar and Raghunath spoke about why the vulture's place in the ecosystem cannot be filled by any other creature. Any discussion about vulture is loud on biomagnification: how man-made chemical toxins enter the food chain and affect vultures as they pick at carrion.

This resources to create the labels were generated by the alumni group, members chipping in with contributions. Raghunath points out he would want the initiative to be extended to other schools including his

alma mater, The Hindu Higher Secondary School, and that would depend on whether help beyond the batch is forthcoming.

This is not the first time Raghunath is interacting with students on the subject of species conservation. He is a brand strategist working with environment and nature conservation NGOs and creates awareness about the subject among communities living in the creases between wildlife sanctuaries, particularly the younger generations in their midst. He has done this work among forest-based communities in Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka.

Among his other significant campaigns are the one on tiger reserves and another on elephants. Titled Elephany, the latter (an art project for children executed during the pandemic) celebrated jumbos, creatures seemingly breathed into life just for the felt-tip caricature pen.

Says Raghunath: “Every elephant is a gardener par excellence. In its lifetime, one without any major twists, an elephant will plant 18 lakh trees/plants, spreading seeds through its dung.”



▼ (Left) The uneven pavement slabs, and (below) unhygienic walkway on a section of the pavement in Meenambakkam.



A difficult walk for pedestrians

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

The State Highways' Department should review the condition of pavements along a section of GST Road in Meenambakkam. On the walkway, the manhole lids are broken and protruding, posing a risk to pedestrians' safety.

S. Keerthana, a pedestrian, says, "The pavements have been constructed at a higher level. Pedestrians give it a wide berth. Along the walking path, a row of vehicles are parked, forcing pedestrians to walk on the carriageway amid the traffic, and there are no speed



breakers, further aggravating the situation. On the walkway, the pavement slabs are shaky, have plummeted, and are protruding. Pedestrians should watch their steps."

V. Kanmani Vijayakumar, a pedestrian, says, "The area along the metro rail pillars (constructed on a walkway area) is an open toilet. Sewage stagnates there posing a health risk. Pedestrians cannot use the road due to parked vehicles and heavy traffic."

Further, towards Chennai International Airport, Tirusulam, the manhole lids are broken. This can cause pedestrians to have their toes struck. The lids are protruding, some at a low level.

The iron and steel round sheets around the lids are visible and rusty. Moreover, gaps can be observed between manhole lids and utility holes. Feet can get bruised and struck."

NGO distributes stationery



▼ Members of Manasathottu, a non-governmental organisation in Pammal led by its founder, M. Paneerselvam, distributed free notebooks, stationery and guides to Class IX students, who are children of conservancy staff, at Suriyammann Kovil Pond bund walkway in Pammal.

MSN Stars bag SMCA trophy

MSN Stars bag SMCA trophy
Rakesh Parthas's fine 81 enabled MSN Stars clinch the 41st SMCA Champions Trophy cricket tournament held at Nelson Wahe Guru Cricket Ground, Kandigai, near Vandalur, with a 33-run win over MSN Lions.

The scores
Final: MSN Stars 228/6 in 30 overs (Md Asif Gr 32, A. S. Santhosh 78, Rakesh Parthas 81) bt MSN Lions 195 in 28.4 overs (Asif Ahmed 34, N.

V. Chirag 27, Ajith Wala 28, Mari Appan 66, G. Inbanathan 3/35, V. Sachin 3/43, Kishore Kumar 3/26).

Semifinals: Sachin Cricket Foundation 127/7 in 27 overs (C. Dhilipan 31, Pravin Tny 33) lost to MSN Lions 128/4 in 18.5 overs (M. Sridhar Raj 48, R. Karthikeyan 32).

MSN Stars 171 in 29.2 overs (A. S. Santhosh 46, Mohammed Ashif 25, N. Dinakar 3/22) bt Mighty Warriors 129 in 28.3 overs (Arunachalam 34, Ashuthosh Yadav 3/32).

Christwood School marches past a milestone

At the institution's Decennial Thanksgiving Celebrations, outstanding students were honoured

Christwood School marked a significant milestone in its journey with its Decennial Thanksgiving Celebrations, commemorating 10 years of transformative learning, character formation and holistic development.

Established in 2016, Christwood School has grown into one of Chennai's leading ICSE institutions, nurturing nearly 2,000 students through a distinctive blend of academic rigour, values-based education and future-focused learning, said a press release. Over the past decade, the school has built an outstanding reputation for excellence in academics, music, sports, leadership development and co-curricular achievements at regional,



▼ David C. Paul and Rev Abraham Thomas present the Christwood Trophy for the Best Outgoing Student to Judah Jeslan Chester. Also seen in the picture are S. Alfred Devaprasad and Vijayakumar, along with parents.

national and international levels, it added.

The institution is widely recognised for its innovative programmes in STEM Education, Robotics and Artificial Intelligence, Nature Ecology, Career Guidance and Entrepreneurship, supported by modern infrastructure and technology-enabled classrooms.

Delivering the decennial thanksgiving address, David C. Paul, Exec-

utive Chairman of Globus Medical Inc., USA, congratulated the Christwood community on its remarkable accomplishments within a short span of ten years.

Reflecting on the rapid technological advancements shaping the modern world, particularly the emergence of Artificial Intelligence, Paul emphasised the importance of strong foundational values in preparing young people for an

increasingly dynamic and uncertain future. He noted that Christwood's emphasis on character, integrity, discipline and service would enable students to remain focused, resilient and progressive amidst global change.

S. Alfred Devaprasad, CEO and Correspondent of Christwood School, reflected on the institution's inspiring journey from a fledgling school established in 2016 to

a vibrant centre of learning recognised for academic excellence and innovation. He acknowledged the unwavering support of parents, teachers, students, alumni and well-wishers who have contributed to the school's growth and success.

The celebrations were attended by several eminent personalities, including P.W.C. Davidar, IAS (Retd.), Rev. Dr. Abraham Thomas, Abraham Mani, Joshua Madan along with guests from the fields of education, industry and public service. A highlight of the evening was the performance by Christwood's 300-member choir and orchestra, whose inspiring musical presentation captivated the audience and showcased the institution's commitment to artistic excellence. The event also featured the presentation of the prestigious Christwood Trophy for the Best Outgoing Student, jointly awarded to Judah Jeslan Chester and Emily Nathania in recognition of their exceptional academic performance, leadership qualities and outstanding contribution to school life.

Crooners beat commuting blues on Chennai's suburban trains

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN



A Methuselah among train singing groups

Every day, at set hours in the morning and evening, a compartment in the local electric train on the Chennai Central-Tiruvallur suburban line morphs into a concert hall. Listening in to the voices from this decades-old amateur train singing group

On the 7.30 a.m. local from Tiruvallur to Chennai Central, compartment three (third from the motorman's cab) doubles as a jukebox. A one-off model, this jukebox cranks out live singing performances. First-timers are usually gobsmacked to hear vocal notes drowning the whir and whine of the suburban electric train and rising in cadence over the occasional clatter of its wheels. No professional singers in sight; nor trained musicians. And the singing can sometimes get ragged around the edges. Commuters are the voices, untrained, occasionally coarse-textured, but irresistibly real.

It is a group forged on the commute. People drawn from different walks of life, different offices, staying together on the commute because they have been singing together as the train carries them to work and home again. It is an "encore" on the 6.25 p.m. local from Chennai Central

to Tiruvallur, the group flexing their vocal cords again. This is a motivational reminder that between deadlines at work and chores at home, there is always a seat of relaxation to nestle into.

This "commuters choir" is as loosely defined as its daily playlist (Tamil and occasionally Hindi songs) and its roster of singers. As in any word-of-mouth tradition, there are multiple strands to its identity and history. Singers would reel off a diversity of names for the group. Some have given it a moniker, "Rail Ragam". Others hold on to a more idealised vision of it, choosing to keep it nameless, thereby deepening mystique. I. Jayaseelan, an advocate and a key member of the group, has an origin story for the group that melds with cosmogony upholding Big Bang Theory. "Nobody started it; the group was born suddenly. Nobody knows how," observes Jayaseelan. P. Venugopal, who joined the group in 2003 and contributes to the music

on the move with banjos, takes a "creationist" view, pointing out that a railway employee started it, and the young group was dandled and nourished by a diversity of commuters. Points of agreement include the group's longevity, close to 40 years old. Composition of the group: staff from Government Hospital, Secretariat, LIC, Harbour, law professionals associated with the High Court and from many private enterprises as well. There is no formal membership. People hop on and off the way they would a train.

However, to be able to hold court in a crowded compartment, a voice accustomed to the scrutiny of an audience helps. Those who sing invariably are given to the habit of singing in challenging settings. Jayaseelan reveals that he has a music troupe called "Inisai Saral". Music instruments such as rhythm pads are brought in by members. Even the sides of a compartment are used as surface for drumming.

The singers on the Chennai Central- Tiruvallur suburban line

On the commute, the singers are known to be offered small gifts, usually eats, if a listener is moved by the singing. "The best gifts are not materialistic; they come as appreciation which we accept with both hands," points out Jayaseelan. "Often, listeners get so lost in the music that they miss their destination, overshooting it by a few stations. Sometimes, they deliberately miss their destination to listen in to more songs."

A train compartment is a shared space, and some commuters might want the sanctity of such spaces to be protected, along with their peace. And that would mean hey do not sign up for the impromptu concert.

"Sometimes, the singers might get carried away, and get too loud for the non-participants' comfort. There have been instances where a singer has been 'led away' by the railway police. Not arrested, just led away," says Jayaseelan.

The advocate notes "the singing will not die down; and the phenomenon is hardly unique to the Chennai Central to Tiruvallur local. There is a long-lasting singing group on the Chennai Beach to Tambaram suburban line; and another on the Chennai Beach to Tiruvallur line."

What is more delectable than the singing in these train groups is the notes of camaraderie and relaxation that are struck silently. Strangers become companions. Weary commuters find solace. An old soul feels renewed, breathing in the air of nostalgia.

For details about the group, call 94441 07353



This unit changed tracks

From devotional to film songs, Pallavaram Return to Tambaram Local, this train commuters music group has experienced notable shifts but is still 'singing' strong

Suburban train singing groups rarely change tracks. Almost everything, from the timings and compartment to the route and genre, is "notated" with indelible ink. And the settings and processes continue without a semitone of variation. The singing group on the Tambaram to Chennai Beach suburban line strayed off this predictable course.

First up, the route. Around 30 years ago, the group whirled into soundscape on the Pallavaram Return, a service originating at Pallavaram station at 9.30 a.m. and screeching to a halt at Chennai Beach. Om Balachandran, employed as public relations inspector at the Anna Salai post office, is by his own admission, a member of this group not by the strength of his vocal cords, but his cochlea. He can sound Descartian if he chose to: "I listen, therefore I am (a member of this group)." And this is what Balachandran "the listener" has to say: the route changed around the pandemic when "Pallavaram Return" service was waved into retirement. Since then the group is associated with the 8.50 a.m. Tambaram local. The "mobile concert hall" is the third compartment from the guard van.

"Still, a majority of the members are from Pallavaram and Chromepet," Balachandran emphasises. The group has had another notable shift: from hymns to hits. In its early days, devotional songs were its staple. And then filmy earworms (Ta-



The group in 2011 when it was called Pallavaram Return Singing Group; and (below) now as Tambaram Local Singing Group. The music ends every day at Chennai Beach. PHOTOS: A.MURALIDHARAN AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mil and occasional Hindi songs) wriggled into the centre stage. Now, there is a mix with film songs in a predominant position. However, every singing session is ushered in with a devotional song.

S. Harishankar, whose daily commute transports him to the Secretariat where he is in a team that takes care of all matters pertaining to the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, the premises and the processes, has been a long-time member. He has reasons to view this compartment as a relief, even an escape from the mundane and persistent burdens of life. And also as a space for companionship.

When it burst on the scene, the group was composed of friends, ten of them. And the number stands at around 30, a clutch of them (three to four) trained for professional stage singing. The thirty does not account for the silent participants, seemingly distant but engrossed in the proceedings.

In fact, the fandom of this group, nicknamed

"The Train Friends", stretches across tracks. I. Jayaseelan, an advocate with the Madras High Court who is part of the singing group on the Chennai Central to Tiruvallur suburban line, detrains from his regular commute to board this train just for the singing.

Besides the camaraderie among members, which is extended to counterparts from singing groups on other suburban locals such as Jayaseelan, there is respect for fellow passengers, even those frowning at the "concert". Balachandran explains: "Occasionally, when the singing group receives a negative response, even if one passenger objects to the singing, saying it prevents them from having a quiet journey, we immediately stop singing." It takes courage to pursue one's passion, and social consciousness to keep it tempered. This group has evidently got this two-sided equation uncannily right.

'Yoga Parks' to come up at two iconic institutions in Chennai

Under an Ayush initiative, Regional Research Institute of Unani Medicine in Royapuram and National Institute of Siddha in Tambaram are clearing the decks for the establishment of spaces that promote yoga



PHOTO SANDEEP SAXENA

LIFFYTHOMAS

Two institutions from Chennai – National Institute of Siddha in Tambaram and Regional Research Institute of Unani Medicine in Royapuram – figure among the list of spaces in various that are to be promoted as Yoga Parks.

An initiative of the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, Yoga Park Portal encourages corporates, resident welfare associations and other like-minded groups to promote these spaces for wellness programmes.

As on the date, the portal has more than 60 parks across cities registered with them with four being from Tamil Nadu.

A 'Yoga Park' would serve as a dedicated space developed within existing 'parks' in both rural and urban areas, with support from Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives of companies.

These parks are designed to provide a structured, accessible, and inclusive environment for the regular practice of yoga and wellness activities, says a note on the website. The initiative aims to promote healthy lifestyles, community participation, and preventive healthcare by offering nearby residents a serene and well-equipped space for daily yoga practice and holistic well-being.

On June 21, which is International Day of Yoga, both these institutions will be hosting Yoga Day and other wellness programmes.

The huge space that these institutions have is one reason why they easily qualify to be promoted as Yoga Parks.

National Institute of Siddha, for instance, is spread across 14 acres and runs a medical college along with the hospital. Yoga is offered as a speciality and is also prescribed to patients. The Institute is opening up its campus for corporates to invest in improving its infrastructure. "We have identified an open area roughly measuring 200 sq metre within our campus, which can be promoted for yoga, so we have registered for funding under CSR," says a senior staff with the Institute.

For more details, visit <https://yoga.ayush.gov.in/yogapark>

A *growing dump* near New Perungalathur

The spot is located at Alapakkam village in Nedungundram panchayat. Through responsible waste management, the gated communities nearby can ensure the dump does not assume monstrous proportions

PRINCE FREDERICK

Sticklers for source segregation of waste can have a Blue Screen of Death (BSoD) moment when they see their green and dry waste reunited in unholy matrimony. That is the nightmare of every person conscientiously following proper waste management practices in their personal turf. To be certain their waste is not adding to a dump, some of these people, each a real *rara avis*, decide to “utilise” shred by shred the waste they generate at home. They spare themselves a BSoD

moment in this manner. They compost the biodegradable waste, squirrel away the recyclable waste till the day in the week the recycler they have signed on (usually along with other like-minded, similarly conscientious neighbours) turns up. Being paranoid does help protect the planet.

And sometimes, not paranoia, but plain facts force their hand in this manner. Do not be surprised to find a growing number of residents of enclaves and gated communities along a new bypass road, one connecting to New Perungalathur at GST Road, taking waste management into their own, con-

scientious hands. The trigger for this approach is the garbage they just handed over showing up round the corner. A patch by the side of this bypass road is being used as a dumping spot by the Nedungundram panchayat.

Jayaraman Srinivasan is among a group of residents at SSM Nagar which is on this bypass road, and located diametrically opposite the alarmingly developing garbage dump.

“The garbage from the SSM Nagar does not end up there, as community has signed up with an entity that takes the garbage elsewhere. Nedungundram panchayat collects garbage from

surrounding neighbourhoods and communities including Seshadri Nagar, Isha Flats and TVS Villas and dumps it here. When I contacted the Nedungundram panchayat, a top functionary expressed helplessness on the part of the civic body to find an alternative spot; and that lack of choice had led them to use this patch for dumping.”

Jayaraman notes that this is causing a problem of secondary dumping, illustrating how individuals arrive in cars and offload garbage on to this patch.

One also notices waste pickers rummaging through this garbage. With these activities, this spot seems to be hurtling to-

wards being “accepted” as a regular dumping spot.

The only solution under the given circumstances that could be effective is communities being proactive in the management of the waste they generate. Through sustained campaign, awareness drives and encouragement, a group SSM Nagar residents have got around 500 households to keep aside their recyclable waste for a recycler to collect it. Other communities could take a leaf out of their book.

Says Jayaraman: “S&P Villa and Shrusti Villa Phase I are also doing a bit of dry waste segregation. More communities should do the same.”

At Alapakkam village near New Perungalathur. PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK



Montessori educators receive directorship award



▼ Hema Sridharan and Priya Grace Christabell (right) receiving the citation from Uma Shanker and Shalini Gopalakrishna, president and treasurer respectively of the Indian Montessori Center - Bengaluru. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Hema Sridharan and Priya Grace Christabell, faculty with Indian Montessori Training Courses (IMTC) - Chennai, were recently conferred with the 'Independent Directorship Award'.

The directorship is awarded to educators after a rigorous process that includes the submission of theoretical papers and practical training experience, both of which extend for over a few years.

The citations were presented by Uma Shanker, president, and Shalini Gopalakrishna, treasurer of the Indian Montessori Center (IMC), Bengaluru.

An IMC-certified director of training courses can set up a teacher training centre, which is an important milestone in further spreading Montessori education in Tamil Nadu, a release stated.

The first teacher training centre in Tamil Nadu

was set up in 1998 by Uma Shanker. Till date, over 150 teachers employed in Greater Chennai Corporation schools have undergone the Montessori teacher training conducted by IMTC-Chennai and Kalvi Trust for Research and Education, the release added.

Preparing students for a future-ready workforce

The Hindustan Institute of Technology and Science (HITS), Padur, in collaboration with the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) and Ethnotech Academy, will soon launch a future skills centre to train students in emerging technologies.

The Hindustan Center for Future Skills will prepare students for careers in Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning, Data Science and Analytics, Cloud Computing, Cyber Security, Industrial Automation and Robotics, AR/VR and Metaverse Technologies, IoT and Smart Systems, Digital Marketing and Project Management.

The centre is being established to bridge the gap between academic education

and rapidly evolving industry requirements by providing students with practical training, live industry projects, internships, and experiential learning opportunities.

Through collaborations with leading technology companies - IBM, Apple, AWS, Microsoft, Cisco, Intel, Schneider Electric, Autodesk, Adobe, Meta, PMI, Pearson, Tally, and MathWorks - the center will provide globally relevant learning experiences and industry-recognized credentials.

Non-HITS students can enrol with a minimum +2 qualification.

For details, call M. Murali Krishna (Academics) at 9989086120; for admissions, call 8668093935.

MSME workshops in Guindy

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute in Guindy is conducting a workshop on "mobile phone repair and service" from June 23 to 25.

Participants will learn about fundamentals of the mobile phone technology.

The institute is also organising a workshop on "E-Sevai" on June 23 and 24. Participants will learn about issuing various certificates including: income, nativity,

community, legal heir, small and marginal farmer and also about certificates relating to welfare schemes of the government.

Another workshop on Foundations of AI and Digital Marketing will be held from June 23 to 25.

Yet another workshop on using Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal will be held on June 24.

For details, call 8668100181/ 9360221280.

Thirukkural competition in August

Shriram Ilakkiya Kazhagam, the literary wing of Shriram Group, is conducting its annual State-level Thirukkural competition on August 29 and 30 at CSI Jessie Moses Matriculation Higher Secondary School in Anna Nagar and at Vels Vidyashram in Pallavaram respectively. It is meant for school, college (including post graduation) and polytechnic students.

According to a press release, the events include: elocution, drawing and painting, and essay writing.

Those interested to take part can collect the application forms from



the branches of Shriram Chits or download from www.shriramchits.com Shriram Ilakkiya Kazhagam has been conducting this competi-

tion every year since 1988 with the aim of inculcating the values and teachings of Thirukkural among youngsters.

Job fair on July 11 at Loyola College

The Rise & Give Life Foundation is organising a job fair on July 11 at Loyola College. According to a press release, around 500 companies will take part. This includes companies from manufacturing sector, banking and finance, IT and ITES, healthcare, pharmaceutical, education, logistics, tourism, and retail. No fee will be charged for pre-registered candidates but a fee of ₹100 will be charged from those who attend without prior registration, adds the press release.

To register visit, www.givelifes.com or call 75300 88293.

Ticket booking time reduced to 5 seconds in CUMTA's app



The Chennai One App of Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority has introduced a new feature called "One Click Payment: CUMTA UPI." According to a press release, the feature reduces the ticket booking time from 60 seconds to five seconds. Also, commuters can avail this facility to get the first ticket for ₹1.

CUMTA encourages the public to use this facility to travel seamlessly using the Chennai One App, adds the press release.

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Bike captain on a mission

Rapido bike taxi operator 'Karate' Mahalakshmi gets back home in the wee hours to ensure other women have a safe ride home late in the night



Mahalakshmi has worked with various institutions as a karate instructor.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

LIFFY THOMAS

Women wary of travelling at night with a male driver has someone to turn to: Rapido 'Captain' from Chennai, 45-year-old Mahalakshmi Ramalingam. She offers bike rides on Rapido late in the night. She is known as 'Karate Mahalakshmi' for a reason: she has been teaching and practising karate for two decades.

"From 9 p.m. to 1 a.m. my bookings are reserved for women, especially those returning from a long-distance trip alighting at Koyambedu bus terminus or Perambur railway station and unable to get a bus," says the resident of Mogappair who has been with the ride-hailing app for the last two years.

Prior to that, Mahalakshmi had worked as assistant karate instruc-

tor with various schools including Velammal Group of Schools, Chennai Public School and Queen Mary's College, where she is often greeted by students who appreciate her influence as a trainer.

Her journey into martial art training began when she was 19, her mother enrolling her in a karate class in the neighbourhood for self-defence. "I lost my father when I was 17 and that protective feeling was mis-

sing at home. I was overweight for my age with thyroid-related complaints, and people made fun of me," says Mahalakshmi.

Although karate empowered and boosted her confidence, she faced many hardships at home and in the workplace.

A school dropout, Mahalakshmi had to work to support her family, being the eldest child. She started by taking up odd jobs. Working as a karate instructor did not address the financial crunch.

"During April and May, we would not get any salaries as schools were not having classes," she says. Later, through a friend she got to know about Rapido. Mahalakshmi says the job has its challenges but on the upside, it offers flexibility.

"I have done close to 6,000 rides with both male and female riders. In some situations you have to be tough and certain others, it is better to ignore the taunts," says the captain who takes 10-15 rides a day.

Genuine expressions of thankfulness from women she had safely dropped at night serve as a motivation factor for Mahalakshmi.

A fellow journalist with *The Hindu* has been a regular rider with Mahalakshmi. She has ferried her many a time for a column featuring Chennai's night life.

Mahalakshmi's first love remains karate and she wants to impart self-defence training to women at Rapido so that they can take late night rides.

In her view, driving and martial arts are indispensable skills for every woman. Mahalakshmi is being helped by well wishers to fulfil her dream of establishing a self-defence and karate academy for women and girls.



Wheels and reels

This Rapido captain uses Instagram to motivate women to be financially independent

Salwar kameez-clad, an earpiece resting around her neck, K. Bhuvaneshwari greets viewers on her Instagram videos with a familiar refrain "Hello, makalle" before launching into a piece of advice.

This captain, a term used for the driver of a bike taxi for ride hailing platform Rapido, is only two months old in Instagram. Through her videos, she encourages women to be financially independent and explore livelihood opportunities.

On her Instagram handle named happy_livinghub, almost every video is about how she has benefitted from becoming a gig worker and how one can use their driving skills to enter the workforce.

A single mother, Bhuvaneshwari has switched many jobs in the last two decades. She has had stints in a web designing firm as Search Engine Optimisation executive, dabbled in marketing and sales jobs, worked with an import and export firm and also in a housing and properties company.

With Zomato, she worked for nearly six years. "Gig jobs are best for women, there is so much flexibility and each workplace has given me a new experience," says the 39-year-old who recently completed a course in three and four-wheeler driving



from ANEW in Anna Nagar.

If it was her mother who motivated her to try out new things; the nudge to post videos on Instagram came from her daughter studying in college.

In one of her most popular posts, she talks about earning ₹55,000 a month. "That video got 26,000 views and I keep getting calls from women on how to make use of their driving skills," Bhuvaneshwari says 49 rides a day is her highest count.

Through referrals, Bhuvaneshwari has earned ₹60,000 in the last two years.

"A mobile and a vehicle are enough for women to be financially independent. I always tell people not to depend on anyone else," she says.

Bhuvaneshwari has learnt classical dance and also plays volleyball.

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